Inspector Goole

Represents and promotes socialism, responsibility and compassion. He is the primary catalyst in the play.

Represents their conscience – represents morality and is Priestley's social voice in the play. Determined, discerning and a solid, unshakeable character in pursuit of the truth and **'he creates at once an impression of massiveness, solidity and purposefulness."**. Direct, unemotional and grows in stature as the play progresses. The inspector dismisses the Birling's ostentatious display of wealth, power and self- importance through his line of questioning. He intimidates them, which exposes their culpability. He is mysterious and omniscient through his knowledge of the events of Eva's life and death. Through his line of questioning, he controls the speech, actions and movement on stage and grows in stature and authority. Inspector Goole serves several functions in the play. He acts as the storyteller, linking all the separate incidents together into one, coherent story and through this he highlights the **"A chain of events" (may have driven her to suicide)**. Priestley has him to supply dates for events, or fill in background about the girl. He also behaves rather like a priest, someone to whom characters confess their sins, helping them to see the extent of their involvement in the downfall of Eva Smith, and encouraging them to acknowledge their guilt and repent.

Goole creates moments of tension and intrigue and acts as vehicle for Priestley's moral message. Through the Inspector's final dramatic speech, Priestley skilfully warns the audience of the potential social disasters of failing to support or help those in need in society and reminds them that '**it is better to ask for the earth than take it.'** The omniscient Inspector is used by Priestley to further convey his views on collective / social responsibility. The Inspector is used very effectively to highlight the corruption and the selfish attitudes of the twentieth century society.

Key Quotes

- 'Need not be a big man but he creates at once an impression of massiveness, solidity and purposefulness."
- "He is a man in his fifties, dressed in a plain darkish suit of the period. He speaks carefully, weightily and has a disconcerting habit of looking hard at the person he addresses before actually speaking"
- "Two hours ago a young woman died in the Infirmary. She'd been taken there this afternoon because she'd swallowed a lot of strong disinfectant. Burnt her inside out, of course"
- "A chain of events" (may have driven her to suicide)
- "it's better to ask for the Earth than to take it"
- "Goole. G. double O-L-E"
- "it would do us all a bit of good if sometimes we tried to put ourselves in the place of these young women counting their pennies in their dingy little back bedroom"
- (To Gerald) "And you think young women ought to be protected against unpleasant and disturbing things?"
- "A girl died tonight. A pretty, lively sort of girl, who never did anybody any harm. But she died in misery and agony-hating life-"
- "If there's nothing else we have to share our guilt"
- Millions of Eva Smiths and John Smiths
- 'We are all members of one body'
- 'And you've slammed the door on her face'

Themes

Social Responsibility

Social Class

Morality

Collective Responsibility